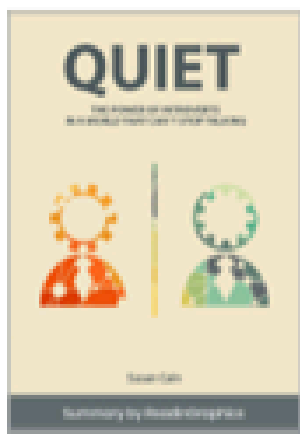




QUIET

The Power Of Introverts in a
World That Can't Stop Talking

SUSAN CAIN

The Big “So What”



Many people believe that to be an achiever or a great leader, you must be bold, action-oriented, outgoing, and aggressive, i.e. you must be an extrovert. In this book, Cain explains why this perspective is flawed, why introverts may be severely undervalued, and **how we can bring out the best in ourselves and others by changing the way we see introversion.**

In this summary, we've distilled and re-organized the key ideas from the book into 3 parts:

- Understanding Introversion and Extroversion
- Debunking the Extrovert Ideal
- Living, Loving and Working Optimally



Understanding Introversion and Extroversion



There is no universally accepted definition of an “introvert” or an “extrovert”. However, **psychologists generally agree that they differ in several ways:**



They function optimally with different levels of outside stimulation;



They work differently and are motivated differently; and



They have different social styles.

No one is a pure introvert or extrovert. Our inborn temperaments can be changed to some extent, and we also behave differently depending on the circumstances. We'll now examine the 3 key differences between introverts and extroverts, and if/how they can be bent or changed.

KEY QUOTES

“If there is only one insight you take away from this book...I hope it's a newfound sense of entitlement to be yourself.”

“Whoever you are, bear in mind that appearance is not reality.”



Response to Stimulation



Physiologically, introverts and extroverts respond differently to environmental stimuli.

- The amygdala in our brain is like an emotional switchboard—it takes in sensory information and uses these inputs to tell our body how to respond. You can guess a child/infant's natural temperaments by observing his/her reactions. Those with an excitable amygdala will react more wildly (e.g. howl or wriggle) to new people and objects, and think/feel more deeply about what they've noticed.
- Our temperaments affect how we interact with our environment to shape our adult personality. An extroverted child raised in a safe, attentive environment can mature with a huge personality (e.g. Tony Robbins or Oprah Winfrey), whereas the same child raised in a dangerous environment without constructive outlets for his/her energy may end up in delinquency.
- The orchid hypothesis by David Dobbs says that children with highly-reactive amygdalae are like orchids. They're more strongly affected by both positive and negative experiences. Hence, they wilt easily and may tip into depression or anxiety if they experience challenges like abuse or parental death. However, with good parenting and a stable environment, they can become exceptionally empathic, caring individuals who thrive in the areas they care about.

KEY QUOTES

"Introverts and extroverts often need very different levels of stimulation to function at their best."

"The high-reactive babies were not misanthropes in the making; they were simply sensitive to their environments."

"Every behavior has more than one cause. Don't ever forget that!"

- Jerry Kegan



Thinking and Working Style



Introverts and extroverts also work and think differently.

- Extroverts tend to act quickly (and sometimes rashly), are more comfortable with risks and multi-tasking, and are driven by the thrill of pursuing rewards like money and status.
- Introverts tend to work more slowly and deliberately, focus on one task at a time, and are relatively less attracted to wealth and fame.

"If genius is one percent inspiration and ninety-nine percent perspiration, then as a culture we tend to lionize the one percent. We love its flash and dazzle. But great power lies in the other ninety-nine percent."



This is partially due to differences in rewards-sensitivity, or the tendency to seek rewards and goals like money, social status, sex and influence.

- Extroverts tend to be more rewards-sensitive; they're stimulated by achieving economic, political, and hedonistic goals. This "high" gives them the energy to work hard, play hard and take risks. However, people who are too sensitive to rewards may get carried away, e.g. become so excited about potential winnings from the stock market that they overlook the warning signals.
- On the other hand, introverts are less rewards-sensitive; they're more likely to have a plan and stick to it, since they're better at regulating their emotions and delaying gratification.



Problem-solving. Extroverts are better at handling information-overload, pressure and multi-tasking, while introverts are better at solving complex problems through clarity, patience and persistence.

- Extroverts tend to focus on what's in front of them and direct most of their energy to the current goal. They're action oriented, are more likely to take short-cuts, or abandon a problem if it gets too frustrating. When extroverts make a mistake, they often bulldoze their way through and speed up rather than slow down.
- Introverts prefer to contemplate, imagine possibilities and make plans for their future. They tend to think of the "what-ifs", study the data thoroughly, and think before they act. They typically downplay rewards, and persevere slowly but steadily on a task.



Social Styles

Introverts and extroverts also have different social skills and needs.



Extroverts need company and dislike solitude.

- They tend to talk more than listen, are comfortable mingling

KEY QUOTES

"Extroverts seem to get an extra buzz from the pursuit and attainment of their goals."

"Reward sensitivity on overdrive gets people into all kinds of trouble."

"It's as if extroverts are seeing 'what is' while their introverted peers are asking 'what if'."

*"It's not that I'm so smart... It's that I stay with problems longer."
- Albert Einstein*

"If you're an introvert...you have the power of persistence, the tenacity to solve complex problems, and the clear-sightedness to avoid pitfalls that trip others up."

"Your degree of extroversion seems to influence how many friends you have...but not how good a friend you are."

with large groups of people, never seem to run out of things to say, and may even blurt things out unintentionally.

- They prefer to confront conflict head-on, and respond well to competition and aggression.



Introverts prefer deep, meaningful discussions and one-to-one interactions, ideally with close friends, colleagues, and family.

- They enjoy solitude, listen more than talk, consider their responses carefully and dislike small talk and conflict. Thus, they can be very likeable and engaging in an intimate social setting.
- In fact, introverts' sensitivity may show up physically, e.g. blushing or perspiring when they're flustered. These traits are valuable socially as they convey humility, a desire to avoid aggression and abide by social rules.
- Introverts generally prefer to avoid conflict, and respond better to nurturing, friendly people.



Stretching your Personality



Nature vs Nurture: Your temperament is inborn, while your personality is shaped from the complex mix of your inborn traits, cultural influence and personal experiences. Only 40-50% of key personality traits, including introversion and extroversion, are heritable.



You can't change your inborn temperaments, but you can learn to control your impulses and stretch your personality to some degree.

- The pre-frontal cortex is the part of your brain that handles logic, planning, and analysis; it can moderate your amygdala's impulses.
- When your sensitive amygdala reacts wildly to something new, your frontal cortex can intervene to soothe these impulses, such as rationalizing that you can handle the novelty or through positive self-talk. Thus, an introvert can

KEY QUOTES

"Physical lack of cool may be more socially valuable than we think."

"Introverts like people they meet in friendly contexts; extroverts prefer those they compete with."

"Some say that temperament is the foundation, and personality is the building."

learn to overcome his shyness, and an extrovert can learn to be quiet.



The Free Trait Theory by Professor Brian Little also suggests that, although we have fixed personality traits, **we sometimes act out of character, especially when it comes to “core personal projects”**, i.e. work, tasks, or people that are especially important to us. An introvert who's usually soft-spoken may become unusually passionate or excited about something that he/she cares deeply about. It's like taking on a temporary “free trait” and switching to extrovert mode.



However, we *cannot* switch off the amygdala or our true nature; we merely suppress it. If we constantly act out of character (even for core personal projects), we'll feel the strain, like a rubber-band that's overstretched.

- In short, our natural discomfort still surfaces in the amygdala; Practice/training only affects how quickly our frontal cortex can neutralize the impulses.
- In fact, our true selves often seep out through “behavioral leakage” or unconscious body language. For example, an introvert may unconsciously look away when engaging a stranger whereas an extrovert would look at the person in the eye.

Debunking the Extrovert Ideal



Today, management and cultural norms in America favor extroversion over introversion. However, **both personality types have their strengths and are vital for success**.



Extroversion wasn't always a cultural ideal. In the book, Cain traces the shift from the “Culture of Character” to “Culture of Personality”.

- Before the 18th century, the focus was on character, with associated concepts like honor, discipline, and integrity.
- The interest in personality grew alongside the rise of the self-help industry. Americans became increasingly obsessed with ways to become more popular, influential, confident

KEY QUOTES

“We can stretch our personalities, but only up to a point. Our inborn temperaments influence us, regardless of the lives we lead.”

“Extroversion is an enormously appealing personality style, but we've turned it into an oppressive standard to which most of us feel we must conform.”

“We're told that to be great is to be bold, to be happy is to be sociable. We see ourselves as a nation of extroverts—which means that we've lost sight of who we really are.”

and competitive. Commercial ads played up the advantages of being bold, charming, outspoken and gregarious (as opposed to being shy and inconspicuous).

- By the 20th century, the prevailing belief is that the ideal self is someone who's assertive, sociable, and comfortable being in the spotlight. Cain calls this the "Extrovert Ideal".

 To research how the Extrovert Ideal is manifested in modern society, Cain personally visited, researched and observed many prominent individuals and institutions. Here are some highlights:

- Tony Robbins and Salesmanship. At Robbin's *Unleash the Power Within* (UPW) experience, Cain found herself surrounded by loud music, cheering, adrenaline-pumping sessions and dramatic challenges like walking on hot coals. Robbins was the perfect embodiment of power and the superior mind, brimming with energy, confidence and a larger-than-life presence. His belief and energy was so infectious that the audience accepted his aggressive upselling and happily bought whatever he pitched.
- Harvard Business School (HBS) and Charismatic Leadership. Students at the HBS are taught that leaders act confidently and can make decisions with incomplete information. Students walk with purpose and confidence, communicate with energy, dress sharply, and are expected to be vocal and attend lots of social functions to build a huge network. HBS students are conditioned to believe that extroversion is essential to success in the business world, and even the introverts try their best to be extroverted.
- Saddleback Church and quiet evangelism. At this evangelical church, Cain met with pastor Adam McHugh. As an introvert, McHugh initially struggled with public expectations that he should be enthusiastic, warm and mingle regularly with people in the community. Thankfully, the growth of social media gave him (and other introverts) a new channel to engage others in the community. McHugh has been advocating a more balanced path to god, including a mix of extroverted practices and quiet, contemplative practices.

KEY QUOTES

"If Abraham Lincoln was the embodiment of virtue during the Culture of Character, then Tony Robbins is his counterpart during the Culture of Personality."

"This school is predicated on extroversion... your grades and social status depend on it."

-A Harvard Business School student

 While extroversion has its strengths, it's simply untrue that extroversion is a prerequisite for success.

- Many famous people—from inventors to leaders and artists—are introverts. In fact, people like van Gogh, Bill Gates, Eleanor Roosevelt, Al Gore, Warren Buffett, and Mahatma Gandhi, probably achieved what they did because of their introversion.
- It's estimated that about one in every 2 or 3 Americans are introverts. Rather than condition everyone to act like extroverts, it makes more sense to understand and leverage the unique strengths of both introverts and extroverts.
- In fact, research and studies suggest that introversion can be just as vital as extroversion.

 **Leadership.** Studies show that extroverted leaders are not necessarily more effective than introverted leaders.

- Jim Collins found that charismatic, larger-than-life leaders are less effective in transforming companies than unassuming leaders who put aside their egos and focus on building their institutions.
- Adam Grant also found that introverted leaders are better at nurturing proactivity. Extroverted leaders tend to dominate others, dampen proactivity, and are stronger only in leading passive staff who don't show initiative. On the other hand, introverted leaders are better at leading initiative-takers, since they tend to listen after and adopt others' suggestions.

 **Mastery.** Solitude, or the ability to work independently, is vital for excellence in any field, because it enables "deliberate practice".

- Mastery requires focused and intentional improvement. Chess grandmasters spend almost 5x as many hours as intermediate-level players in self-study in their first 10 years of chess play. Elite musicians use solo-practice to master their craft and treat group-practices as a leisure activity.
- Deliberate practice is best done alone because (a) it requires intense focus and others' presence can be distracting, and (b) you must identify and master tasks or knowledge that are specifically challenging to you, and this is best tackled alone.

KEY QUOTES

"Some of our greatest ideas, art, and inventions—from the theory of evolution to van Gogh's sunflowers to the personal computer—came from quiet and cerebral people who knew how to tune in to their inner worlds and the treasures to be found there."

"We don't need giant personalities to transform companies. We need leaders who build not their own egos but the institutions they run."

"Introverted leaders create a virtuous cycle of proactivity."

"If you want to improve what you're doing, you have to be the one who generates the move."

*- Research Psychologist,
Anders Ericsson*



Solitude is also vital for creativity and productivity. Today, many organizations are adopting open-concept offices, group brainstorming and collaborative learning, under the wrong assumption that these will enhance creativity and team synergy. Cain calls it this trend the “New Groupthink”.

- The success of online crowdsourcing has led organizations to model their face-to-face interactions after the openness of the internet. However, it's wrong to assume that online and face-to-face interactions work the same way.
- Great inventors and engineers are like artists: they work best when they can focus fully on their tasks. Programmers who had privacy and control over their workspace were found to perform 10x as well as programmers who didn't.
- Excessive stimulation hinders rather than promotes learning. You learn better after a quiet stroll through the woods, compared to a walk down a noisy city street. Multitasking can also reduce productivity and increase mistakes by up to 50%.
- Hence, open-concept offices are more likely to create distraction and stress than promote creativity. Reebok International shelved its open-concept office when its shoe designers gave feedback that they needed peace and quiet to concentrate. Jason Fried, cofounder of 37signals, allows his staff to work away from the office and enforce no-interruption work hours.



Group work may also hinder creativity:

- Studies have shown that the larger the group, the lower the number and quality of ideas generated. This is probably because (a) social loafing occurs as some people sit back while others do the work, (b) only one person can talk at a time, so people are unproductive while waiting for their turn, and (c) people hold back their inputs for fear of looking stupid.
- In fact, studies found that people don't just hold back their ideas—the inputs from their peers can fundamentally change their perspective.

KEY QUOTES

“Instead of distinguishing between online and personal interaction, we used the lessons of one to inform our thinking about the other.”

“The New Groupthink elevates teamwork above all else. It insists that creativity and intellectual achievement come from a gregarious place.”

“Introverts prefer to work independently, and solitude can be a catalyst to innovation.”

“If personal space is vital to creativity, so is freedom from ‘peer pressure.’”

“We perceive talkers as smarter than quiet types— even though grade-point averages and SAT and intelligence test scores reveal this perception to be inaccurate.”

- In a group setting, the louder and more aggressive people also tend to drown out good ideas/opinions of the quieter ones. Rousing speeches and loud discussions may also lead poorer outcomes due to emotional and ego-led decisions.
- The only exception is during online brainstorming, where individuals do better in a group setting. This is because people are still working on their own despite being connected with others online. People may also be more creative when they work alone in a busy café or city, rather than in total isolation in the mountains.

Living, Loving and Working Optimally



Making the Most of Introversion & Extroversion

Introverts and extroverts have different strengths and weaknesses. Neither is perfect, and we need both for society to function well.

 In the book, Cain shows the power of an extrovert-introvert partnership through a detailed case study of how Franklin Roosevelt's outgoing and confident nature was balanced by Eleanor Roosevelt's social conscience and sensitivity.

- Being highly-sensitive, introverts tend to be more emphatic, philosophical or spiritual, rather than materialistic or hedonistic. They are more in-tune with others' feelings, have stronger consciences, and hold themselves to high behavioral standards. Yet, being slow and cautious could mean missed opportunities.
- Extroverts are driven and glad to be in the spotlight, thus providing visibility, speed, risk-taking and the ability to move forward in uncertain situations. Yet being fast and aggressive, they're more likely to make mistakes.

KEY QUOTES

"We fail to realize that participating in an online working group is a form of solitude all its own."

"The sensitivities and the strengths are a package deal."

"We need our Eleanor Roosevelts as surely as grazing herds depend on their sensitive antelopes."

"These traits—alertness, sensitivity to nuance, complex emotionality—turn out to be highly underrated powers."



Maximizing Personal Potential

To be at your peak performance, seek to operate from your sweet spot, and occasionally stretch yourself when the situation requires it.



Find your “sweet spot”, i.e. the optimal level of stimulation where you work best and feel most energetic. This allows you to:

- Identify the ideal careers, businesses, hobbies and social life that can improve your overall satisfaction and success.
- Manage the sub-optimal situations more effectively when you push yourself outside your comfort zone, e.g. request for advance notice to prepare for speeches or networking events.



Manage your thinking:

- Know where you sit on the rewards-sensitivity spectrum. If you're a rewards-prone extrovert, direct your energy to building things/businesses and inspiring others, but deliberately pause, reflect on warning signals and learn from mistakes. If you're an *introvert*, learn to be seen and heard in your natural way, e.g. sharing your ideas quietly but powerfully.
- Solve problems by tapping on extroverts' ability to handle pressure and diverse information/tasks, and introverts' clarity, patience and persistence.



Close communication gaps. Conflict often arises from a lack of understanding between introverts and extroverts. For example, at the end of a socially-overstimulating day, introvert Tom just wants to return to his quiet self and recharge. However, his extrovert wife, June, desires his company, and feels upset that Tom is so engaging with others but clamps up once he's home. The angrier and louder June becomes, the more Tom withdraws (and feels hurt by her lack of understanding), which upsets June further in a vicious cycle.

KEY QUOTES

“Even though we can reach for the outer limits of our temperaments, it can often be better to situate ourselves squarely inside our comfort zones.”

“The trick for introverts is to honor their own styles instead of allowing themselves to be swept up by prevailing norms.”

- As an extrovert, if you feel your anger mounting, take a few deep breaths to calm down first.
- As an introvert, even if you don't wish to fight back, learn to take a firm stand and say "this is not ok with me". Use your empathy to consider the true meaning behind the other person's agitation.



Create the right social setting where everyone can enjoy themselves. Let extroverts be in the centre of attention or handle a large group, and allow introverts to have cozy, one-on-one chats.



Stretching yourself



Use these 3 steps to identify your core personal projects, as these are the most natural for stretching yourself:

- Think back to your childhood and what you wanted to be when you grew up. Examine the underlying reasons for those choices, e.g. if you wanted to be a dancer, was it due to the thrill of performing, to move gracefully, or to wear beautiful costumes?
- Consider the work that you're attracted to, e.g. the work you volunteer for, and what energizes you.
- Notice what you envy, as they reflect your desires.



Find your restorative niches, i.e. places or activities where you can be in-character and recharge.

- Before taking on a new job, consider if it will offer you the time and opportunity for such restorative niches.
- Use a "Free Trait Agreement" to strike a more optimal balance:
 - i. Set a *quota* for what you'd do to achieve your goals, e.g. an introvert may decide to attend up to 2 social events a week, then retreat to his/her restorative niche without guilt.
 - ii. Agree on a balanced arrangement with your *spouse or*

KEY QUOTES

"Even if you're stretching yourself in the service of a core personal project, you don't want to act out of character too much, or for too long."

friends that meets your mutual needs, e.g. an extroverted-introverted couple may agree to spend 50% of their date nights quietly at home and 50% out mingling with people.



Teamwork and Collaboration

Enhance results by using a blend of group and solitary activities.



Offer a range of work options—such as solo workspaces, cafes, quiet zones, and mingling spaces—so people can choose to interact or retreat into their private corners when needed.



Assign tasks based on people's strengths and tap on the natural symbiosis in introvert-extrovert relationships.



To improve learning effectiveness in schools, use a mix of cooperative learning and deliberate practice.



Nurturing Introverted Children

Avoid forcing introverted kids to become more assertive or energetic. Instead, try to understand how they see the world.



Introduce novelty gradually. Since introverts naturally recoil from novelty and may be overstimulated by new people, places and events:

- Allow your kids to take things at their own pace. For very young children, facilitate the initial introductions to other kids, and be around for as long as they need to feel comfortable.
- Encourage them when they take social risks, e.g. by saying "I saw you going up to your new classmates earlier. I know it can be difficult, and I'm proud of you."



Build confidence. Don't push them too hard nor overprotect them.

- Instead, help them understand that their feelings are normal and can be managed. Be supportive, help them take baby

KEY QUOTES

"The way forward...is not to stop collaborating face-to-face, but to refine the way we do it."

"Slowly your child will see that it's worth punching through her wall of discomfort to get to the fun on the other side. She'll learn how to do the punching by herself."

steps to overcome their fears, e.g. exposing them to a new item from afar, then gradually increasing the engagement each time.

- Be a role model to show them how to meet strangers and friends in a calm and friendly way. Over time, they'll learn to reassure themselves and regulate their own fears and behaviors.
- Create engagement opportunities, e.g. find topics that energize them, encourage them to choose responsibilities in a group setting (e.g. note-taking), and find activities where they can meet other kids while still having their own space.



Learning and Education. Most schools are designed for extroverts, with overstimulating environments and little time to think or create.

- Remember that introversion isn't a problem to be fixed. Respect each child's uniqueness and tailor your approach accordingly.
- Most introverts have 1-2 deep interests, and the best way to draw them out is to give them a topic that's so compelling that they forget their inhibitions.
- An ideal learning environment should come with a mix of movement and group/collaborative work, with downtime, one-to-one interaction and independent projects.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This book is packed with anecdotes, examples, and resources including:

- Details of Cain's research and personal meetings with experts, researchers, leaders, professionals etc., as well as relevant research and studies on introversion/extroversion;
- A closer look at Americans' obsession with extroversion, compared with the quiet persistence valued by Asians;

KEY QUOTES